

PANIC ATTACK WORKBOOK

CBT Tools to Stop Panic in Its Tracks

Evidence-Based Strategies for
Managing and Overcoming Panic Disorder

Includes:

Interoceptive Exposure Exercises
Catastrophic Misinterpretation Challenging
Breathing Retraining Techniques
Panic Diary & Tracking Tools

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PANIC ATTACK WORKBOOK

CBT Tools to Stop Panic in Its Tracks

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DISCLAIMER: This workbook is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional mental health treatment. If you are experiencing severe panic attacks, please seek help from a licensed therapist.

If you are in crisis, call 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).

WHAT IS PANIC DISORDER?

Panic disorder is characterized by recurrent, unexpected panic attacks - sudden surges of intense fear that reach a peak within minutes.

Common symptoms include:

- Racing or pounding heart
- Sweating, trembling, or shaking
- Shortness of breath or feeling smothered
- Chest pain or discomfort
- Nausea or stomach distress
- Dizziness or lightheadedness
- Chills or hot flashes
- Numbness or tingling
- Feeling detached from yourself (derealization)
- Fear of losing control or dying

Key Point: Panic attacks are NOT dangerous. They are your body's fight-or-flight system misfiring. You will NOT die, go crazy, or faint.

THE PANIC CYCLE EXPLAINED

Understanding the cycle keeps you trapped:

1. TRIGGER: A body sensation or situation
2. CATASTROPHIC THOUGHT: 'I'm having a heart attack!'
3. ANXIETY INCREASES: More adrenaline released
4. MORE BODY SENSATIONS: Heart races faster, breathing changes
5. MORE CATASTROPHIC THOUGHTS: 'Something is really wrong!'
6. FULL PANIC ATTACK: Peak fear, intense symptoms
7. AVOIDANCE: You avoid similar situations next time
8. CYCLE STRENGTHENS: Avoidance confirms danger belief

BREAKING THE CYCLE:

This workbook targets steps 2 & 7. By changing your interpretation of symptoms and facing feared situations, the cycle breaks.

BODY SENSATIONS LOG

Track your body sensations and the thoughts they trigger:

Sensation	Catastrophic Thought	Rational Alternative	Anxiety (0-10)

Example: Heart racing -> 'Heart attack!' -> 'Exercise does this too, it's adrenaline' -> 6

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE: SPINNING IN A CHAIR

Exercise: Spin in an office chair for 60 seconds

- Creates dizziness and disorientation
- Mimics lightheadedness during panic
- Shows you that dizziness is temporary and safe

SUDS RATINGS (Subjective Units of Distress Scale, 0-10):

Trial 1: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 2: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 3: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 4: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 5: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Sensations experienced: _____

Similarity to panic (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE: BREATHING THROUGH A STRAW

Exercise: Breathe only through a thin straw for 60 seconds

- Creates sensation of restricted breathing
- Mimics 'can't get enough air' feeling
- Proves you won't suffocate

SUDS RATINGS (Subjective Units of Distress Scale, 0-10):

Trial 1: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 2: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 3: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 4: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 5: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Sensations experienced: _____

Similarity to panic (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE: HYPERVENTILATION

Exercise: Breathe rapidly and deeply for 30 seconds

- Creates tingling, lightheadedness, chest tightness
- Mimics many panic symptoms directly
- Shows symptoms pass quickly when you stop

SUDS RATINGS (Subjective Units of Distress Scale, 0-10):

Trial 1: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 2: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 3: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 4: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 5: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Sensations experienced: _____

Similarity to panic (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE: RUNNING IN PLACE

Exercise: Run in place vigorously for 60 seconds

- Creates racing heart, sweating, breathlessness
- Mimics cardiac symptoms of panic
- Proves racing heart is normal and safe

SUDS RATINGS (Subjective Units of Distress Scale, 0-10):

Trial 1: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 2: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 3: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 4: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 5: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Sensations experienced: _____

Similarity to panic (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

INTEROCEPTIVE EXPOSURE: BREATH HOLDING

Exercise: Hold your breath for 30 seconds

- Creates chest pressure and urge to breathe
- Mimics suffocation fear
- Shows your body will breathe automatically

SUDS RATINGS (Subjective Units of Distress Scale, 0-10):

Trial 1: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 2: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 3: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 4: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Trial 5: Before: ____ During (peak): ____ After 1 min: ____ After 3 min: ____

Sensations experienced: _____

Similarity to panic (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

CATASTROPHIC MISINTERPRETATION CHALLENGING (1/5)

Body Sensation: _____

My Catastrophic Interpretation: _____

Evidence FOR this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Evidence AGAINST this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Alternative explanation (rational): _____

How many times have I had this sensation without dying/going crazy? ____

What would I tell a friend who had this thought? _____

Belief in catastrophic thought BEFORE (0-100%): ____

Belief in catastrophic thought AFTER (0-100%): ____

CATASTROPHIC MISINTERPRETATION CHALLENGING (2/5)

Body Sensation: _____

My Catastrophic Interpretation: _____

Evidence FOR this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Evidence AGAINST this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Alternative explanation (rational): _____

How many times have I had this sensation without dying/going crazy? ____

What would I tell a friend who had this thought? _____

Belief in catastrophic thought BEFORE (0-100%): ____

Belief in catastrophic thought AFTER (0-100%): ____

CATASTROPHIC MISINTERPRETATION CHALLENGING (3/5)

Body Sensation: _____

My Catastrophic Interpretation: _____

Evidence FOR this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Evidence AGAINST this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Alternative explanation (rational): _____

How many times have I had this sensation without dying/going crazy? ____

What would I tell a friend who had this thought? _____

Belief in catastrophic thought BEFORE (0-100%): ____

Belief in catastrophic thought AFTER (0-100%): ____

CATASTROPHIC MISINTERPRETATION CHALLENGING (4/5)

Body Sensation: _____

My Catastrophic Interpretation: _____

Evidence FOR this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Evidence AGAINST this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Alternative explanation (rational): _____

How many times have I had this sensation without dying/going crazy? ____

What would I tell a friend who had this thought? _____

Belief in catastrophic thought BEFORE (0-100%): ____

Belief in catastrophic thought AFTER (0-100%): ____

CATASTROPHIC MISINTERPRETATION CHALLENGING (5/5)

Body Sensation: _____

My Catastrophic Interpretation: _____

Evidence FOR this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Evidence AGAINST this interpretation:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Alternative explanation (rational): _____

How many times have I had this sensation without dying/going crazy? ____

What would I tell a friend who had this thought? _____

Belief in catastrophic thought BEFORE (0-100%): ____

Belief in catastrophic thought AFTER (0-100%): ____

[illegible]

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PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION SCRIPT

Tense each muscle group for 5 seconds, then release for 10 seconds.

Notice the contrast between tension and relaxation.

- | | |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1. Hands & Forearms: | Make fists, squeeze tight |
| 2. Upper Arms: | Bend elbows, flex biceps |
| 3. Shoulders: | Shrug shoulders up to ears |
| 4. Forehead: | Raise eyebrows high |
| 5. Eyes & Cheeks: | Squeeze eyes shut tight |
| 6. Mouth & Jaw: | Clench jaw, press lips together |
| 7. Neck: | Press head back gently |
| 8. Chest: | Take deep breath, hold |
| 9. Stomach: | Tighten abdominal muscles |
| 10. Back: | Arch back slightly |
| 11. Thighs: | Press legs together, tighten |
| 12. Calves: | Point toes up toward shins |
| 13. Feet: | Curl toes under |

Total time: approximately 15-20 minutes. Practice daily for best results.

PANIC DIARY - Page 1

Entry 1

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 2

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 2

Entry 3

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 4

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 3

Entry 5

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 6

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 4

Entry 7

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 8

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 5

Entry 9

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 10

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 6

Entry 11

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 12

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 7

Entry 13

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 14

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 8

Entry 15

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 16

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 9

Entry 17

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 18

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

PANIC DIARY - Page 10

Entry 19

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

Entry 20

Date: _____ Time: _____ Duration: _____ min

Situation/Where I was: _____

Symptoms (circle): Heart racing / Dizzy / Sweating / Chest pain / Numb /
Shaking / Breathless / Nausea / Hot/Cold / Detached / Other: _____

Peak anxiety (0-10): ____ Catastrophic thought: _____

What I did (coping): _____

Outcome: _____

What I learned: _____

AGORAPHOBIA EXPOSURE HIERARCHY

List situations you avoid due to panic fear, from least to most scary:

10	
20	
30	
40	
50	
60	
70	
80	
90	
100	

Start with lowest item. Practice until anxiety drops by 50%, then move up.

PROGRESS NOTES:

[illegible]

MY PANIC TOOLKIT & RELAPSE PREVENTION

MY PANIC TOOLKIT (what works for me):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

RELAPSE PREVENTION PLAN:

Early warning signs that panic is returning:

- _____
- _____
- _____

If panic returns, I will:

- _____
- _____
- _____

My therapist/support person to contact: _____

REMEMBER:

- A panic attack has **NEVER** killed anyone
- Symptoms **ALWAYS** pass (usually within 10-20 minutes)
- You have survived 100% of your worst days
- Recovery is not linear - setbacks are normal, not failures